

[13](#)

An interesting fact: From the time of the Great Fire in London in 1666 to the end of World War I in 1918, commodity prices in England were unchanged on balance. That's two and one-half centuries!

[14](#)

Having founded the premier marketing research firm of its day, the Harvard-educated Yankelovich knew better than most the uses and abuses of counting.

[15](#)

Some economists argue that when excessive rewards go to those whose returns come from the redistribution of wealth rather than from the creation of wealth—they single out government, law, and financial services, including stock traders and money managers—the economy suffers. These redistributors of wealth contrast with wealth creators such as builders, manufacturers, and engineers. Paradoxically, however, the fastest growth among college engineering majors today is not in traditional engineering— aeronautical, electrical, mechanical, and the like—but in “financial engineering” for those seeking careers as hedge fund managers and Wall Street “quants.”

[16](#)

Bankers and investment bankers also have jumped on the bandwagon. In mid-2008, beleaguered Citigroup, even as it reported year-to-date losses of \$17 *billion* (not to mention layoffs totaling 28,000), emphatically reaffirmed its plan to purchase the naming rights for the New York Mets' new baseball park, to be named Citi Field. Cost: \$400 million.

[17](#)

In a refinement of this system, some giant fund managers employ groups of “portfolio counselor” teams, each handling a relatively small portion of the fund's assets. Whether these teams can be multiplied ad infinitum in order to produce superior returns remains to be seen.

[18](#)